AGED CARE CASEY

AN INDEPENDENT LOCAL RESOURCE

The Casey & Cardinia Family Guide to *Support at Home*

2026 EDITION

Plain-English answers for families in Clyde North, Cranbourne, Berwick, Narre Warren, Pakenham, Officer & surrounds

What's inside

- What changed on 1 November 2025, and why it matters for your family
- How to start the My Aged Care process — step by step
- The 8 Support at Home funding levels explained simply
- What you'll pay out of pocket — and what's fully free
- Residential aged care funding, including the 1 October 2026 update
- 12 questions to ask any home care provider
- Casey & Cardinia-specific resources, contacts, and local services

> **A note from us:** This guide is written by a Casey-based team who found the aged care system genuinely confusing to navigate for our own families. We're currently going through the aged care registration process ourselves. Until that's complete, we built Aged Care Casey — and this guide — to give every local family a straight, honest answer and connect you with local providers who may be able to help right now.

1. What changed on 1 November 2025

Australia's aged care system went through its biggest change in a generation. If you've heard confusing or conflicting things about "Home Care Packages" versus "Support at Home," here's the plain-English version.

The short version

On 1 November 2025, the old Home Care Packages program closed to new arrangements and was replaced by a new program called Support at Home. If your parent or loved one was already receiving a Home Care Package before that date, their existing arrangements are being transitioned — but anyone starting the process now goes straight into the new system.

What's genuinely different

What changed	What it means for you
Funding levels	Went from 4 package levels to 8 classification levels — more precise matching to actual need
Maximum funding	Up to $80,137 per year for the highest level of need (classification 8, from 1 July 2026; indexed each July)
Care management fees	Capped at 10% of your budget
Clinical care	Nursing, physiotherapy, and other clinical services are now 100% government funded — no matter your income
Personal care	From 1 October 2026, personal care (showering, dressing, non-clinical continence management) moved into the Clinical Supports category and became fully government funded, with no out-of-pocket contribution where it's approved in your support plan and funding is available
Assessment	One national assessment system now covers eligibility for all types of aged care, replacing separate processes

> **Why this matters for Casey families:** Casey is Victoria's largest council area by population, and many local families are working out aged care for the first time. That means understanding the system yourself, and moving quickly once you're assessed, genuinely matters here more than in most parts of Melbourne.

2. How to start the process — step by step

Here's exactly what happens, from the first phone call through to services actually starting at home.

Step 1 — Make contact

Call My Aged Care on 1800 200 422, or apply online at myagedcare.gov.au. You don't need a referral from a doctor to do this yourself — anyone can call on behalf of a parent or loved one, with their permission.

- A GP can also refer directly through their practice software (ask at your next appointment)
- Hospital discharge planners can refer if your loved one has recently been in hospital
- You, a family member, or a friend can call directly — no professional referral required

Step 2 — Phone screening

A short 15–20 minute phone call. They'll ask about daily living challenges, health conditions, living situation, and whether there's a family carer involved. Based on this, you'll either be referred for entry-level support (CHSP) or a comprehensive assessment (Support at Home).

Step 3 — The home visit assessment

An assessor visits your home — typically 45 to 75 minutes. In Victoria this is generally done through the Aged Care Assessment Service (ACAS), now part of the national Single Assessment System. They'll ask about 12 areas of daily life: physical health, memory and thinking, emotional wellbeing, daily activities, home safety, social circumstances, and more.

> **Important tip:** Describe your worst days, not your best days. Families often understate difficulties out of pride or habit, which can result in a lower classification than is genuinely needed. Be honest and specific.

Step 4 — Classification & waiting

You'll receive a letter with your funding classification (explained in the next section) — median wait time from referral to assessment is around 25 days. After that, you may be placed in a queue for funding to actually be released, since national demand currently outstrips supply.

Step 5 — Choosing a provider

Once funding is released, you have 56 days to sign with a provider and start services, or the funding is reassigned to someone else on the queue. You can compare providers on the My Aged Care website, ask your GP, or ask people in your community who they'd recommend.

> **Casey tip:** The first provider to respond to your enquiry often wins the family's trust simply through speed. Don't wait — once you have your classification letter, start reaching out to local providers the same week.

3. The 8 Support at Home funding levels

Your assessment places you into one of 8 classification levels. Each comes with a different annual (and quarterly) budget. Here's what each level generally looks like in practice.

Level	Approx. annual funding	Typical need
1	~$11,010 / year	Occasional help — domestic assistance, transport, social support once a week or less
2	~$16,451 / year	Regular support — cleaning, light personal care, social support several times a week
3	~$22,537 / year	Structured support multiple times per week — combining domestic, personal, and social needs
4	~$30,469 / year	Daily personal care plus household tasks — showering, dressing, meal prep most days
5	~$40,730 / year	More intensive daily support, often combined with early clinical needs
6	~$49,365 / year	Complex daily needs — multiple visits per day, coordination across services
7	~$59,660 / year	Intensive support approaching residential-level needs, but still safely at home
8	$80,137 / year	Highest level of home-based support — near-nursing level care, multiple daily visits

> **Good to know:** These figures are approximate ranges based on published national figures — your actual classification and budget are determined by your individual ACAS assessment. Budgets are paid quarterly, with unspent funds rolling over up to $1,000 or 10%, whichever is greater.

4. What you'll pay — and what's free

This is the question every family asks, and the new means-testing system genuinely confused a lot of people when it changed. Here's the plain version.

Always fully free, regardless of income

- Nursing care
- Physiotherapy and other allied health
- Clinical wound care and medication management
- Personal care (showering, dressing, non-clinical continence management) — fully funded from 1 October 2026

Means-tested — you may contribute something

- Domestic assistance (cleaning, laundry)
- Transport to appointments and social activities
- Social support and companionship
- Gardening and home maintenance

What determines your contribution

Your situation	Typical contribution level
Full Age Pensioner	About 17.5% of everyday living services and 5% of independence services; clinical care 0%
Part Pensioner / some income	17.5%–80% of everyday living services, depending on income and assets
Self-funded retiree	About 80% of everyday living services and 50% of independence services; clinical care 0%

> **Care management fee:** Every provider deducts a care management fee from your quarterly budget, capped at 10% under the new rules. Ask any provider you're considering to state this fee clearly before you sign — it directly affects how much of your budget goes toward actual services.

5. Residential aged care funding

Not every family's journey stays at home. If residential care becomes part of the picture, here's what's changed.

The AN-ACC funding model

Residential aged care is funded differently to Support at Home — through the Australian National Aged Care Classification (AN-ACC), a daily rate paid per resident based on their assessed care needs.

What	Detail
AN-ACC price (from 1 October 2026)	$303.19 per resident per day, up from $295.64
Average total funding per resident	Rising from an estimated $317 to an estimated $325 per resident per day
Hotelling supplement	Remains $22.15 per resident per day — no change
Care minutes requirements	No change

> **What this means for families:** This funding increase goes to providers, not directly to families, and is intended to help cover rising costs including nursing wages. It doesn't change your personal contribution directly, but it's worth knowing when comparing facilities or asking providers about any price changes — providers must discuss and agree any price increase with you before applying it.

6. 12 questions to ask any home care provider

Whether you're speaking with us or another local provider, these questions help you compare confidently and avoid surprises later.

On services & fit

- 1. What specific services do you deliver directly, and what do you refer out to other providers?
- 2. Do you have workers who speak our family's language or understand our cultural background?
- 3. How consistent are the workers assigned to us — will we see the same person regularly?

On cost & budget

- 4. What is your care management fee, as a percentage of the budget?
- 5. Can you show me a full, itemised price list before I sign anything?
- 6. What happens to unspent funds at the end of each quarter?

On flexibility & control

- 7. Can I change or cancel services with reasonable notice, without penalty?
- 8. If I want to switch providers later, how easily can I transfer my remaining budget?
- 9. Do you offer self-managed options if I want more control over who delivers care?

On quality & safety

- 10. Are your care workers police-checked and screened, and can you show evidence of this?
- 11. What is your process if I have a complaint or a concern about a worker?
- 12. How do you communicate updates about my loved one's care — regular reports, an app, phone calls?

> **Our answer, honestly:** We are an independent local guide, not yet a registered aged care provider ourselves — we're currently going through that process. Right now, every category on this list connects you to a local provider, rather than a service we deliver directly. We don't yet have a formal provider verification process in place, and we'll be transparent as that develops.

7. Local Casey & Cardinia resources

Resource	Contact
My Aged Care	1800 200 422 · myagedcare.gov.au
Casey Hospital	Casey Hospital, Berwick — ask for the discharge planning team
Casey City Council — Ageing Services	casey.vic.gov.au
Cardinia Shire Council — Ageing Services	cardinia.vic.gov.au
South Eastern Melbourne PHN	semphn.org.au
Older Persons Advocacy Network (OPAN)	1800 700 600 · opan.org.au
Carer Gateway (support for family carers)	1800 422 737 · carergateway.gov.au
Aged Care Casey	agedcarecasey.com.au

> **Need help right now?** Visit agedcarecasey.com.au to use our free eligibility checker and funding estimator, or get in touch directly — we'll point you to local providers who may be able to help.